TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Language

What language is — definitions, its defining characteristics, its functions in human life, and the place of English in an engineer's working world.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 1 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. Definitions

Language is the system by which human beings communicate thoughts and feelings through agreed symbols. The definitions most often quoted in this course:

- **Henry Sweet:** "Language is the expression of ideas by means of speech-sounds combined into words. Words are combined into sentences, this combination answering to that of ideas into thoughts."
- **Oxford English Dictionary (in substance):** the words and the methods of combining them used and understood by a considerable community.
- **A working definition for this course:** language is a *system* of *arbitrary*, *vocal* symbols by which a social group cooperates and communicates.

Every word of the working definition carries weight, and the characteristics below unpack it one term at a time.

2. The characteristics of language

CHARACTERISTIC	MEANING
Language is a system	It has structure at every level — sounds combine into words, words into sentences, by rules (phonology, grammar) that speakers obey without being able to state them.
It is symbolic	Words are symbols standing for things, actions and ideas; the symbol is not the thing (the word "water" cannot be drunk).
It is arbitrary	There is no natural connection between a word and its meaning — "water" in English, "pani" in Bengali, "eau" in French; the link exists only by social convention, which is why languages differ and why words must be learned.

It is vocal (primarily)	Speech is the primary form; writing is a later, secondary recording of it. Children learn to speak before they read, and many languages have no written form at all.
It is human and social	Language is a social possession, learned from and used within a community; it is uniquely and fully developed in human beings.
It is dynamic	Languages live and change — new words enter (internet, software), old ones die, meanings shift. A language that stops changing is dead.
It has duality and productivity	A small stock of sounds builds unlimited words, and a finite grammar builds unlimited sentences — speakers routinely produce and understand sentences never before spoken.
It displaces	Language can speak of things absent in time and place — yesterday, tomorrow, the other side of the world — unlike animal calls, which answer only the present moment.

3. Functions of language

- **Communication of information** — the primary function: conveying facts, instructions, knowledge (this course's home ground).
- **Expression of feeling and identity** — emotion, attitude, belonging; accent and dialect mark who we are.
- **Social interaction** — greetings, small talk, politeness formulas: language as social glue rather than information.
- **Instrument of thought** — we plan, reason and remember in words; written language extends thought beyond the memory of one mind.
- **Record and control** — laws, contracts, specifications: language fixed in writing governs behaviour and preserves it across generations.

4. Language and the engineer: why this course exists

English is the working language of world engineering and of the textile trade: specifications, standards, machine manuals, test methods, buyer correspondence and research papers are written in it. A textile engineer from Bangladesh sells to buyers in Hamburg and New York, reads German and Japanese machine documentation in English translation, and writes reports that must survive being read by strangers. The aim of Communicative English is therefore practical, not literary: to make the student able to **receive** technical English accurately (listening and reading) and to **produce** it correctly

(speaking and writing) — the four skills around which the rest of this course is built, beginning with communication itself in the next topic.

5. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Arbitrariness	The absence of any natural link between a word's sound and its meaning; the link is convention.
Duality	Language's two-layer structure: meaningless sounds combine into meaningful words.
Productivity	The capacity to create and understand unlimited new sentences from finite resources.
Displacement	Reference to things removed in time or place.
Dialect	A regional or social variety of a language, differing in pronunciation, vocabulary and grammar.
Register	The variety of language chosen for a situation (formal, technical, informal).

6. Key points and summary

- Language is a system of arbitrary vocal symbols used by a social group for communication — each adjective in the definition names a characteristic examiners ask for.
- Its hallmarks: systematic, symbolic, arbitrary, vocal, human and social, dynamic, dual, productive, capable of displacement.
- Its functions run from information to identity to social control; for the engineer, English is the trade's working medium — the practical reason for this course.

7. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Give the working definition of language and explain the words "system" and "arbitrary" in it with examples.
2. Why is the word "water" itself not water? Name the characteristic this illustrates.
3. "Writing is the primary form of language." True or false — correct the statement with two supporting facts.
4. Explain productivity: how can a speaker produce a sentence that has never been spoken before?

5. Distinguish dialect from register with one example of each from your own life.
6. List four functions of language and give one textile-workplace example of each.
7. Why is English specifically important to a textile engineer in Bangladesh? Give three concrete reasons.
8. What does displacement allow a production manager’s written report to do that a warning shout on the factory floor cannot?

Answer key

1. Language is a system of arbitrary vocal symbols by which a social group communicates. System: sounds and words combine by fixed rules (grammar) — e.g. English places the adjective before the noun. Arbitrary: no natural bond joins sound to meaning — the same liquid is water/pani/eau in three conventions.
2. Because a word is a symbol standing for the thing, not the thing itself — the characteristic of symbolism (and, in the choice of this particular symbol, arbitrariness).
3. False. Speech is primary: children speak before they write, and many languages exist without any script; writing is a secondary device for recording speech.
4. Because the grammar is a finite set of rules for combining a finite vocabulary without limit — mastery of the rules, not memorisation of sentences, lets a speaker assemble genuinely new ones and lets hearers decode them.
5. Dialect: a regional variety — e.g. the Bengali spoken in one district differing in words and accent from another. Register: the variety chosen for the occasion — e.g. formal English in a buyer meeting versus informal Bengali with classmates.
6. Information: a test report’s results. Feeling/identity: a supervisor’s encouraging words marking team belonging. Social interaction: greetings at shift change. Record/control: the written quality specification that binds production.
7. (1) Buyer correspondence and order specifications are in English. (2) Machine manuals, standards and test methods are published in English. (3) Research, higher study and international conferences operate in English.
8. Displacement: the report can describe yesterday’s fault, tomorrow’s plan and a machine in another factory — things absent here and now — while a shout can only react to the present moment.
